With newspapers going overboard with spy tales, the Kerala Police held internal meetings and decided on 14 November 1994 to hand over the investigation to the CBI. But IB was against the idea. The next day the Kerala DGP constituted a Special Investigation Team (SIT) headed by DIG Sibi Mathews to investigate the case. By now IB men were torturing the accused to extract 'confessions'.

On 21 November 1994, Sasikumaran was arrested in Ahmedabad, and Chandrasekhar was picked up in Bangalore. On the same day, IB sent an unofficial (UO) note to the highest authorities in Delhi, to book the accused under Official Secrets Act and implicate Ravinder Reddy of MTAR and Prabhakar Rao in the case. These moves were to tighten the noose around ISRO, and prepare ground for my arrest.

The first indication of dragging me into the plot came on 28 November 1994, when *Kerala Kaumudi* published a false report that I was under house arrest. On this day, the IB sent another UO note recommending that Raman Srivastava may be questioned. Two days later, I was arrested.

The Plot

Till IB Joint Director M K Dhar flew down to Trivandrum on 10 November 1994, there was nothing to link me with the case. In fact, the first UO note the IB had sent to the higher ups said that no espionage had happened. A second UO note, sent after Dhar's visit, said spying appeared to have taken place. A third UO note, after IB could not gather any evidence to substantiate their theory, said it was all a combination of truth, half-truths and lies.

So what urged Dhar to rush to Trivandrum? It was part of his counter-intelligence operations against Pakistan, argues the IB officer in his hilarious book *Open Secrets: India's Intelligence Unveiled*. There may still be a few conspiracy theorists who would find enough masala in that book that tries in vain to argue there was indeed espionage in ISRO.